

XVII Roman numerals

DEVELOPED BY THE ANCIENT ROMANS, THIS SYSTEM USES LETTERS FROM THE LATIN ALPHABET TO REPRESENT NUMBERS.

SEE ALSO

◀ 14–15 Introducing numbers

Understanding Roman numerals

The Roman numeral system does not use zero. To make a number, seven letters are combined. These are the letters and their values:

I	V	X	L	C	D	M
1	5	10	50	100	500	1000

Forming numbers

Some key principles were observed by the ancient Romans to “create” numbers from the seven letters.

First principle When a smaller number appears after a larger number, the smaller number is added to the larger number to find the total value.

$$XI = X + I = 11 \quad XVII = X + V + I + I = 17$$

Second principle When a smaller number appears before a larger number, the smaller number is subtracted from the larger number to find the total value.

$$IX = X - I = 9 \quad CM = M - C = 900$$

Third principle Each letter can be repeated up to three times.

$$XX = X + X = 20 \quad XXX = X + X + X = 30$$

Using Roman numerals

Although Roman numerals are not widely used today, they still appear on some clock faces, with the names of monarchs and popes, and for important dates.

Time



Names

Henry VIII
Henry the eighth

Dates

MMXIV
2014

Number	Roman numeral
1	I
2	II
3	III
4	IV
5	V
6	VI
7	VII
8	VIII
9	IX
10	X
11	XI
12	XII
13	XIII
14	XIV
15	XV
16	XVI
17	XVII
18	XVIII
19	XIX
20	XX
30	XXX
40	XL
50	L
60	LX
70	LXX
80	LXXX
90	XC
100	C
500	D
1000	M